came to the Pythia to consult the gods on either official or private matters, the Pythia invariably replied that the Spartans must first free Athens from the tyrant. The Spartans, who were Hippias's allies, eventually submitted to the alleged will of the gods and sent an army to Athens that deposed Hippias in 510 BCE, leading to the establishment of Athenian democracy.[7]

If a human prophet could falsify the words of a god, then the key problem of religion wasn't solved by creating religious institutions like temples and priestly orders. People still needed to trust fallible humans in order to access the supposedly infallible gods. Was it possible to somehow bypass the humans altogether?

THE INFALLIBLE TECHNOLOGY

Holy books like the Bible and the Quran are a technology to bypass human fallibility, and religions of the book – like Judaism, Christianity and Islam – have been built around that technological artefact. To appreciate how this technology is meant to work, we should begin by explaining what a book is and what makes books different from other kinds of written texts. A book is a fixed block of texts – such as chapters, stories, recipes or epistles – that always go together and have many identical copies. This makes a book something different from oral tales, from bureaucratic documents and from archives. When telling a story orally, we might tell it a little differently each time, and if many people tell the story over a long time, significant variations are bound to creep in. In contrast, all copies of a book are supposed to be identical. As for bureaucratic documents, they tend to be relatively short, and often exist only as a single copy in one archive. If a long document has many copies placed in numerous archives, we would normally call it a book. Finally, a book that contains many texts is also different from an archive, because each archive contains a different collection of texts, whereas all copies of a book contain the same chapters, the same stories or the same recipes. The book thereby ensures that many people in many times and places can access the same database.

The book became an important religious technology in the first millennium BCE. After tens of thousands of years in which gods spoke to humans via shamans, priests, prophets, oracles and other human messengers, religious movements like Judaism began arguing that the gods